

Session 24: The Gog Oracles

Key Takeaways

- Gog represents those among the nations who are hostile to God's purposes.
- Ezekiel's oracle imagines what God must do to deal with evil in the rest of the world to bring about his Kingdom.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 38-39

38:1 And the word of Yahweh came to me saying,
2 "Son of a human,
set your face toward Gog of the land of Magog,
the chief head, Meshech and Tubal,
and prophesy against him
3 and say,
'Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"Behold, I am against you, O Gog,
chief head of **Meshech** and **Tubal**,
4 and I will turn you around,
and I will put hooks into your jaws,
and I will bring you out,
and all your army,
horses and horsemen,
clothed in perfection, all of them;
a great assembly,
large shields and small shields,
armed with swords, all of them,
5 **Persia**, **Ethiopia** and **Put** with them,
all of them with shield and helmet;
6 **Gomer** with all its troops;
Beth-togarmah, of the remote regions of the north, with all its troops,
many peoples with you.
7 Be prepared, and prepare yourself,
you and all your assembly that is assembled about you,
and be on guard for them.
8 After many days you will be summoned;
in the latter years you will come into the land,

when it is restored from the sword,
whose inhabitants have been gathered from many nations,
to the mountains of Israel which had been a continual waste;
and its people were brought out from the nations,
and they are living in security, all of them.

⁹ You will go up, you will come like a storm;
you will be like a cloud covering the land,
you and all your troops,
and many peoples with you.”

¹⁰ Thus says Yahweh Elohim,

“It will come about on that day,
that words will come up into your heart,
and you will scheme an evil scheme,

¹¹ and you will say,

‘I will go up against the land of unwalled villages.
I will go against those who are at rest, that live securely,
all of them living without walls,
and having no bars or gates,

¹² to capture spoil and to seize plunder,
to turn your hand against the waste places which are now inhabited,
and against the people who are gathered from the nations,
who have acquired cattle and goods,
who live at the center of the land.’

¹³ Sheba and Dedan
and the merchants of Tarshish with all its villages,
they will say to you,

‘Have you come to capture spoil?
Have you assembled your assembly to seize plunder,
to carry away silver and gold,

to take away cattle and goods,
to capture great spoil?’”

¹⁴ Therefore prophesy, son of a human,
and say to Gog,

‘Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
“On that day when my people Israel are living securely,
won’t you know it?

¹⁵ You will come from your place out of the remote regions of the north,
you and many peoples with you,
riding on horses, all of them,
a great assembly, and a mighty army;

¹⁶ and you will come up against my people Israel like a cloud to cover the land;
it will come about in the last days,

and I will bring you against my land,
so that the nations may know me,
when I display my holiness through you before their eyes, O Gog."

17 Thus says Yahweh Elohim,

"Are you the one of whom I spoke in former days,
through my servants the prophets of Israel,
who prophesied in those days, for years,
that I would bring you against them?

18 It will come about on that day,
when Gog comes against the land of Israel,"

declares Yahweh Elohim,

"that my hot-anger will go up with my anger,

19 and in my zeal, in the fire of my anger I declare,
that on that day there will surely be a great earthquake in the land of Israel,

20 and they will shake before me,
the fish of the sea, and the birds of the skies,
the beasts of the field, and all the creepers that creep on the land,
and all the humans who are on the face of the ground,
and the mountains will be thrown down,
the steep pathways will fall,
and every wall will fall to the land,

21 and I will call for a sword against him on all my mountains,"
declares Yahweh Elohim,

"every man's sword will be against his brother.

22 and I will enter into judgment with him,
with plague and with blood;
and flooding rain, and hailstones,
fire and brimstone,
I will rain down upon him,
and upon his troops,
and upon the many peoples who are with him,

23 and I will show myself to be great,
and I will show myself to be holy,
and I will make myself known in the eyes of many nations;
and they will know that I am Yahweh."

39:1 And you, son of man,

prophesy against Gog and say,

'Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"Behold, I am against you, O Gog,
prince of Rosh, Meshech and Tubal;

2 and I will turn you around,

and I will drive you on,
and I will make you go up from the remotest parts of the north,
and I will bring you against the mountains of Israel,
³ and I will strike your bow from your left hand,
and I will make your arrows from your right hand fall down;
⁴ upon the mountains of Israel you will fall,
you and all your troops,
and the peoples who are with you;
I will give you as food to birds of prey,
and to the wild beasts of the field,
⁵ you will fall on the open field;
for it is I who have spoken,"
declares Yahweh Elohim.
⁶ "And I will send fire upon Magog,
and on those who inhabit the coastlands in security,
and they will know that I am Yahweh,
⁷ and I will make known my holy name in the midst of my people Israel;
and I will not let my holy name be profaned anymore,
and the nations will know that I am Yahweh, the Holy One in Israel.
⁸ Behold, it is coming and it shall be done,"
declares Yahweh Elohim,
"the day of which I have spoken."

⁹ "And the inhabitants of the cities of Israel will go out,
and they will make fires with the weapons and burn them,
even small shields and large shields,
bows and arrows,
war clubs and spears,
and they will make fires of them for seven years.
¹⁰ They will not pick up wood from the field,
or chop wood from the forests,
for they will make fires with the weapons;
and they will take the spoil of those who despoiled them,
and they will seize the plunder of those who plundered them,"
declares Yahweh Elohim.
¹¹ "On that day I will give Gog a burial ground there in Israel,
the valley of the passers-on east of the sea,
and it will block off those who would pass-on,
and they will bury Gog there and all his horde,
and they will call it, 'Valley of the horde of Gog.'
¹² And the house of Israel will be burying them,
in order to cleanse the land,
for seven months.
¹³ And all the people of the land will bury them,

and it will be for their name on the day that I display my honor," declares Yahweh Elohim.

¹⁴ "And they will set apart men who will constantly pass-on in the land, burying those who were passing-on, those who remain on the face of the land, in order to cleanse it.

At the end of seven months they will make a search,

¹⁵ and those who pass-on in the land will pass-on, and if anyone sees a man's bone, then he will set up a marker by it until the buriers have buried it in the valley of Gog's horde,

¹⁶ and even the name of the city will be 'Horde,' and they will cleanse the land.'"

¹⁷ As for you, son of a human, thus says Yahweh Elohim,

'Speak to every kind of bird and to every beast of the field, "Assemble and come, gather from every side, to my sacrifice which I am going to sacrifice for you all, as a great sacrifice on the mountains of Israel, that you may eat flesh and drink blood.

¹⁸ You will eat the flesh of mighty warriors, and you'll drink the blood of the chiefs of the land, rams, lambs, and goats, bulls, fat ones of Bashan, all of them.

¹⁹ And you will eat the fat unto fulness, and you will drink blood until you are drunk, from my sacrifice which I have sacrificed for you.

²⁰ and you will be filled full at my table, with horses and charioteers with mighty warriors and all the men of war," declares Yahweh Elohim.

²¹ "And I will set my honor among the nations; and all the nations will see my justice which I enact, and my hand which I have set on them.

²² And the house of Israel will know that I am Yahweh their Elohim, from that day and also onward.

²³ The nations will know that the house of Israel went into exile, on account of the fact that they acted treacherously against me, and I hid my face from them; and I gave them into the hand of their adversaries, and all of them fell by the sword.

²⁴ According to their impurity and according to their transgressions I dealt with them,

and I hid my face from them.”

²⁵ Therefore thus says Yahweh Elohim,

“Now I will restore the fortunes of Jacob,
and I will have mercy on the whole house of Israel;
and I will show zeal for my holy name.

²⁶ And they will forget their disgrace,
and all their treachery which they perpetrated against me,
when they live securely on their own land,
with no one to make them afraid.

²⁷ When I bring them back from the peoples,
and when I gather them from the lands of their enemies,
then I will display my holiness through them in the eyes of the many nations,

²⁸ and they will know that I am Yahweh their Elohim,
because I made them go into exile among the nations,
and I gathered them again to their own land;
and I will leave remaining none of them there any longer,

²⁹ and I will not hide my face from them any longer,
for I will have poured out my Spirit on the house of Israel,”
declares Yahweh Elohim.”

Ezekiel 38:1-39:29. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The Identity of Gog

In [Ezekiel 38:2](#) we meet “Gog of Magog, chief prince of Meshech and Tubal.” But who is Gog?

The name Gog is derived first of all from the table of nations in Genesis 10:2 (the sons of Japheth, all located in the north and western Mediterranean). The title Gog could be rooted in a historical figure (= Gyges/Gugu, king of Lydia in west Asia Minor during the late 7th-early 6th century B.C.E.).

“The name seems to relate to one known to the Greeks as Gyges and to the Assyrians as Gugu, who was a powerful king of Lydia in west Asia Minor in the first half of the 7th century. Meshech and Tubal, characterized in 32:26 as a bygone power in the world, are regarded as resurgent, and the old menace come back to haunt their southern neighbors ... Probably this memory, current in Babylonia, had reached the Jewish exiles. Here they are under the authority of 'Gog.' As with the names of nations in ch. 38, so here a great figure of the past is evidently used to define a future threat, just as we might speak of a new Hitler.”

Allen, Leslie C. (1990). [Ezekiel 20-48 \(World Biblical Commentary, Vol. 29\)](#). Thomas Nelson Inc. 204-205.

Gyges and Lydia were never a threat to Israel in any way, but were known as an ancient superpower, which made them ideal as a prophetic image for the rebellious nations.

Gog in [Ezekiel 38-39](#) is an archetypal and symbolic figure who embodies all the features of Israel's historical enemies. He represents all the nations in rebellion against God who must be defeated before the restoration of all things.

There seven nations named as the allies of Gog, representing the fringes of Israel's geographical awareness and the four directions of their compass.

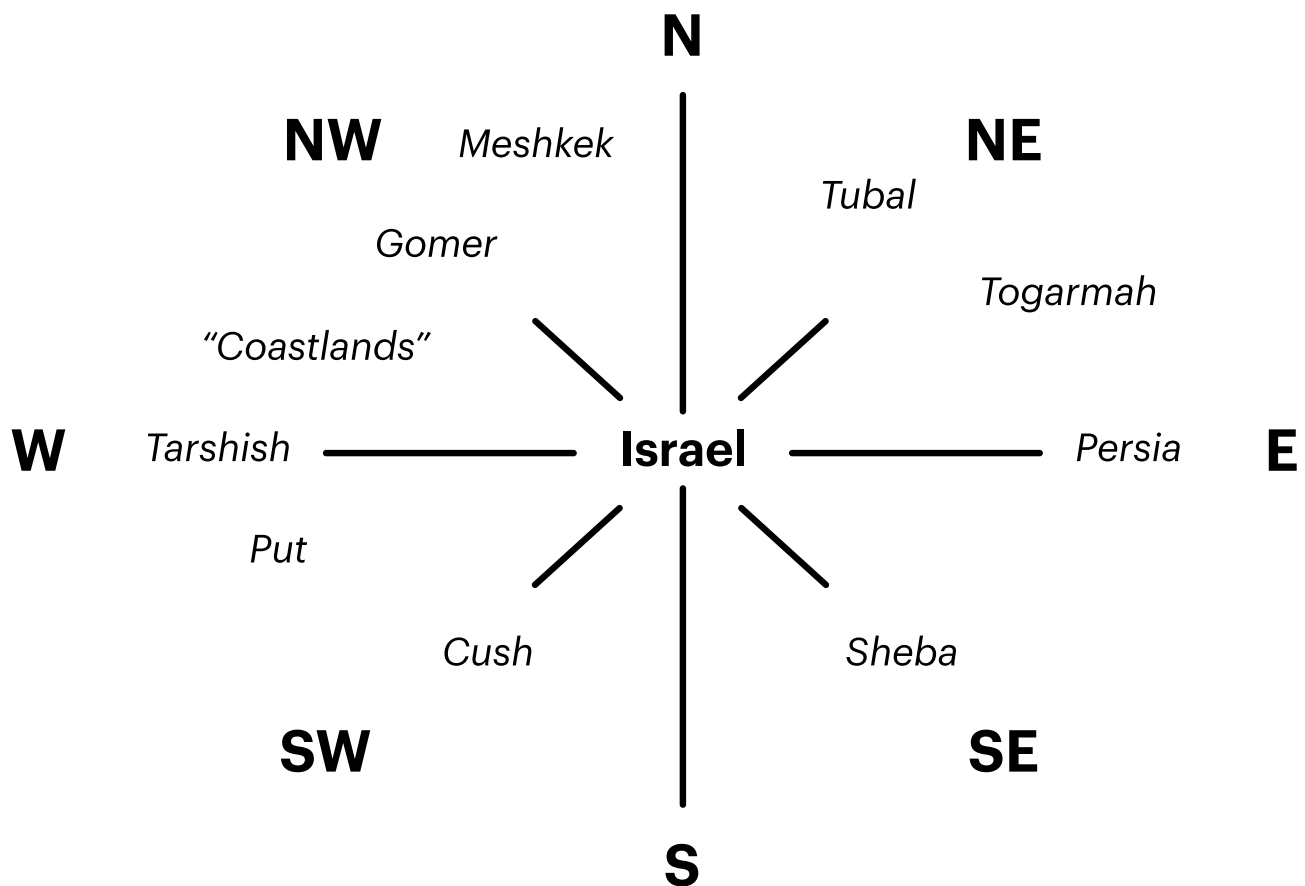
1. North: Meshek, Tubal ([Ezek. 38:3](#), interior of Anatolia = Modern Turkey)
2. East: Persia ([Ezek. 38:5](#))
3. South: Cush, Put ([Ezek. 38:5](#), Ethiopia, Libya)
4. West: Gomer, Beth-Togarmah ([Ezek. 38:7](#), far NW into Western Anatolia and north into Ukraine)

"The names in Ezekiel's lists of allies with Gog form a merismic pattern: they come from the extreme ends of the compass, north, south, east, west, and suggests that the whole world is involved in this attack ... Ezekiel envisions a universal conspiracy against Israel."

Block, Daniel (1998). [The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)](#). Eerdmans.

"These particular nations were selected for two reasons. First, each represents a nation-descendant of Japheth and Ham (not Shem) from the primeval past. Second, with the exception of Persia, they are not well-known historical enemies of Israel but far-flung nations of rumor. Taken together, they represent widely distributed stations on the compass. The oracles depict a global gathering of peoples, from remote localities and from many directions, who converge on the mountains of Israel. In effect, the whole world is against Israel."

Tooman, William A. (2011). [Gog of Magog: Reuse of Scripture and Compositional Technique in Ezekiel 38-39](#) (*Forschungen Zum Alten Testament 2. Reihe*). Mohr Siebeck. 149.



Gog's Allies. Adapted from Tooman, William A. (2011). [Gog of Magog: Reuse of Scripture and Compositional Technique in Ezekiel 38-39](#) (Forschungen Zum Alten Testament 2. Reihe). Mohr Siebeck. 149.

The name “Gog” (גוג) also appears in the Hebrew version of the Balaam oracles that were available to the Septuagint translators of the Torah.

Numbers 24:7 Masoretic Text (NASB)*

Water will flow from his buckets,
and his seed will be in many waters,
and his king shall be higher **than Agag** (מאגג)
and his kingdom shall be exalted.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Numbers 24:7 LXX (Instructor's Translation)

A man will come out from his seed,
and he will rule over many nations
and his kingdom will be lifted higher **than Gog** (מגג)
and his kingdom will become great.

This also matches the text in the Samaritan Pentateuch and in the Septuagint revision of Theodotian and the Old Latin.

The wide textual attestation of “Gog” makes it likely that the original reading of Numbers 24:7 was in fact “Gog” and that the reading “Agag” was a later adaptation of Balaam’s oracle so that it referred to David’s conquest of Amalek (see [2 Sam. 8:12](#)).

When and What? The Scope of the Gog Oracles

The unique feature about this oracle is that it is set after Israel’s return to the land ([Ezek. 38:8, 12](#)). This shows that the larger-scale restoration referred to in [39:21-29](#) cannot refer to the return to the land narrated in Ezra-Nehemiah. Ezekiel here envisions that the return from Babylonian exile will be followed by some greater, more cosmic resistance of the nations against the plan of Yahweh.

The main theological concern of these chapters is that even after Yahweh deals with the evil and rebellion among his covenant people and restores them, there is still the problem of evil and rebellion among the nations at large, especially those distant nations who have never been players in Israel’s history.

Key Themes in the Gog Oracles

These oracles address a gap remaining in Ezekiel’s vision of the future. Yahweh’s restoration of Israel from exile into new covenant life ([Ezek. 38:8, 12, 14; 39:2](#)) only solves one piece of the biblical drama. Yahweh still needs to defeat the powers of evil at work among the nations so that his name can be known to all beyond Israel (connected to the theology of blessing and curse of [Gen. 3:15, 9:25-27](#), and [12:1-3](#)).

The oracles are marked as an eschatological vision in the undetermined far future (“end of years” in [Ezek. 38:8](#); “end of days” in [38:16](#)), and Israel is depicted as restored to the land but living in defenseless, unfortified towns (doesn’t correspond to anything in Ezra-Nehemiah).

Gog as an Archetype of Rebellion

Gog and his hordes are a literary amalgam of the entire prophetic tradition’s portrait of the rebellious nations. Gog and his armies are described with a pastiche of language and imagery from Ezekiel’s descriptions of Egypt and Tyre, as well as descriptions of Assyria and Babylon from many other prophetic texts.

[Ezekiel 38:17](#) makes clear that Gog embodies earlier predictions of a “foe from the North” ([Ezek. 38:6, 39:2](#); see [Jer. 4-6](#), especially [6:22](#)) who is defeated “on my mountains” ([Isa. 14:24-25](#)).

“Ezekiel believed the advent of Gog to be the true fulfillment of these ancient predictions. In the process, a national oracle has been expanded and has assumed apocalyptic significance.”

Fishbane, Michael (1989). [Biblical Interpretation in Ancient Israel](#). Clarendon Press. 477.

This interpretation wove its way into the textual traditions of earlier prophecies as well (see [Num. 24:7](#) and [Amos 7:1](#)).

Almost all the language and imagery used to describe Gog, his hordes, and the events of his defeat are drawn from Ezekiel 1-37 and other biblical texts—especially Isaiah and Jeremiah and the classic flood, Sodom and Gomorrah, 10 plague narratives—even some of the strangest scenes.

For example, after Gog's (second!) sudden defeat in [39:4-6](#), the leftover mess of weapons and armor (described with seven words!) will supply Israel's firewood for seven years, and lead to seven months of burial cleanup. This scene is developed out of [Isaiah 2:4](#), [Isaiah 9:3-5](#), and [Psalm 46:9](#), as well as out of the priestly regulations for dealing with corpses in [Numbers 19:11-19](#) and [Deuteronomy 21:1-9](#).

The ghastly scene of the scavenging animals eating the corpses of Gog's soldiers ([39:17-20](#)) is a burlesque development of [Isaiah 34:6-8](#) and [Zephaniah 1:7](#): Yahweh throws a celebratory sacrificial meal (*zevakh* refers to general sacrifices not made for atonement, see [Lev. 3](#)) and invites his guests.

Gog's seven allies summarize all the patterns of seven in Ezekiel 25-32; this army is the archetype of the rebellious nations ([Ezek. 38:4-7](#)).

Deliberate Prophetic Exaggeration

These oracles consist of eight frames that create vivid mental pictures in graphic detail: They are not linear and logical, and they are not describing a literal sequence of historical events. Rather the frames are piled onto one another to shock and provoke.

"The vision consists of deliberately exaggerated and caricatured language, not literal prediction. Comparable to political cartoons, the frames are not to be interpreted as prophetic literary photography, but as an impressionistic literary sketch."

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit](#). IVP Academic. 321.

There are all kinds of logical inconsistencies between the various frames if we expect them to offer a realistic sequence of future events.

For example, Gog is defeated no less than six times:

1. by an earthquake
2. by sword
3. by a plague
4. by water and fire from the skies ([Ezek. 38:19-22](#), reminiscent of the de-creation poem of [Jer. 4:24-26](#))
5. by a divine smack ([Ezek. 39:2](#))
6. by a second round of fire ([Ezek. 39:6](#))

The corpses of Gog's army are very carefully buried over the course of seven months ([Ezek. 38:11-13](#)). But, all of a sudden the bodies are once again exposed for scavenging animals to eat ([Ezek. 39:17-19](#)).

"The placement of this frame after the scene involving the burial of Gog creates some logical and logistical problems, but the reader is reminded that this is a literary cartoon, and realism may be sacrificed for rhetorical effect. Indeed, as the oracle has progressed the scenes have become increasingly bizarre, climaxing here in a scene more fantastic than all."

Block, Daniel (1998). [The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)](#). Eerdmans.

Gog as the Ultimate Pharaoh

Gog and his hoards are depicted as the ultimate Pharaoh. Yahweh uses their hard and selfish hearts to lead them toward their own defeat. Divine initiative and human sin interplay here in a similar way to Exodus 1-14 and Isaiah 7-14 and 36-39.

Yahweh initiates calling and summoning Gog (38:4, 7, 16), yet Gog comes against Israel with his own selfish motives (38:10-13). Gog is Yahweh's enemy (38:3), yet also an instrument in his divine plan (38:17).

In contrast to Yahweh's instruments Assyria and Babylon, Gog is allowed to do no harm. Israel plays no active role in defense or attack, but Gog is summoned and defeated by Yahweh alone, as a demonstration of his power and holiness (see Exod. 14:13, 17-18).

Yahweh, God Over All Nations

Yahweh's ultimate goal is to be known among the nations ("they will know that I am Yahweh" repeated 7x, cited from Ezek. 37:28). But Yahweh wants to be known as the God over all creation, not only as the national deity of Israel.

The oracles conclude with Yahweh's double goal in Ezekiel 39:21-23. Yahweh will have shown his justice (verse 21) in two ways.

1. After exile, restoration, and the final defeat of all other rebellious nations Israel will come to know Yahweh truly (verse 22).
2. Through Israel's story of facing God's justice along with their own experience all nations will come to know Yahweh as well (verse 23).

Hope

The concluding frame (39:21-29) picks up themes from all the previous oracles of hope in Ezekiel 34-37 with some new emphases.

- Restore the fortunes (39:25 recalls 16:53-58)
- Compassion (39:25, first occurrence in the book so far)
- Remembering past sin (39:26 recalls 16:61-63 and 36:31)
- Return to the land from exile (39:27 recalls 28:25, 34:13, 36:24, 37:21)
- Pouring out the Spirit (39:29, see also "put my Spirit on you" in 36:27; "pour the Spirit" occurs elsewhere only in Isa. 32:15 and 44:3; Joel 2:28; Zech. 12:10)

Reflection Question

What questions or unresolved conflicts do the Gog oracles address?